

Introduction to Human Communication: COMM 108
Lecture Notes OUTLINE: Ch. 2 The Self, Perception & Communication Preferences

I. Self-Concept

A. DEF:

- i. Self-concept is who we think we are.**

B. Versus Self-Esteem

- i. Self-Esteem is how we feel about ourselves**
- ii. Self-Esteem is the emotional component of how you evaluate yourself**
- iii. Positive & negative descriptions of ourselves:**
 - Negative description can be positive and vice versa**
 - This is because we can see a negative description as a place for growth**

C. Development of Both:

- i. Both stabilize in early life**
 - An imprinting window between the ages of ~4 to 8 years old**
 - It is easy to manipulate SC and SE at this age**
 - They both will fully stabilize at about 8-10 years of age**
- ii. Change is possible after the imprinting window but is extremely difficult and requires a lot of determination**

D. Impact on Communication

- i. Accurate self-esteem is important for communication**
 - GOOD (accurate) S-C/S-E = Clear Communication**
 - a. Like a clear window for interpretation and perception of your strengths and weaknesses**
 - b. You have a clear view of what you do good and what you can improve on**
 - POOR (inaccurate) S-C/S-E = Distorted Communication**
 - a. Distorted window for self perception**
 - i. You don't get the details**
 - b. Don't fully understand yourself**
 - c. You cannot see where your strengths and weaknesses lie**

E. Types of "Self"

1. Public Self-Concept:

- a. How I act to build an image of myself in others' mind**
- b. The image I want others to have of me**
- c. Impression management:**

- i. Impression management is referred to as being “on stage”
- ii. This is the act you put on and what parts of yourself you show others

2. Real Self-Concept:

- a. How I see myself
- b. You want to study people’s real self when you speak to them
- c. Honest moment with yourself
 - i. Who am I?
 - ii. What am I?
 - iii. What are my real strengths and weaknesses?
- d. Known as being “backstage”
 - i. Who really are you when you aren’t putting on an act

3. Ideal Self-Concept:

- a. Who do I want to be?
- b. We are always trying to better ourselves
- c. When you set the bar too low you won’t challenge yourself
- d. You are not happy when you don’t set a good goal for your Ideal Self-concept
- e. What we strive to be should be based on our real Self-Concept
- f. If your ideal Self-Concept is viewed with an inaccurate sense of self you will be a reliable worker at a shit job instead of a better version at yourself climbing the corporate ladder

4. How Types of “Self” Fit Together & General Happiness

- a. When there is less overlap between each type of “Self” you get general unhappiness
- b. More overlap across the different types makes you generally happier; public self should have the most overlap with your real Self-Concept
 - i. Ideal Self-Concept should be more stretched away because you should make yourself grow

F. Self-Concept/Self-Esteem & Attributions

1. Attributions:

- a. These are the meanings I make from my experiences using my self-concept and self-esteem as filters
- b. Accurate Sense of Self:
 - i. You will own your successes and your failures
 - 1. “I’m good at this”
 - 2. “I can figure this out”
 - 3. “I’ll get better”

- c. **Inaccurate Sense of Self:**
 - i. **You don't know why you do well, and you think you got lucky when you succeed**
 - 1. **"That's me I not good at this"**
- d. **When asked what kind of student you are with an accurate sense of self you will say you are smart, ambitious, etc.**
- e. **Inaccurate sense of self will make students say they aren't that good in school.**
- f. **Models will not always cover all scenarios, so not every model is accurate**

2. Self-Serving Bias:

- a. **It is a tendency to see our success to be caused by ourselves and our failures to be caused by others**
- b. **Considered a normal mindset in social psychology**
- c. **Self-Serving bias is usually incorrect**
- d. **It is accurate 10-15% of the time**
- e. **It only really attacks one cell within the attribution model**
 - i. **"Fuck my teacher, they can't teach", is usually incorrect**

II. Communication Traits

A. Trait (DEF):

- a. **Behaving in a consistent manner across time and differing situations.**
- b. **Traits are the general tendencies of ones behaviors**
 - i. **"Across time":**
 - 1. **If the trait is assessed at age six it will be about the same at age 17, 20, 50, etc.**

B. Traits as Preferences:

- a. **Not "good" or "bad" things**
- b. **Not an evaluation but a description**
 - i. **How someone prefers to engage others**
 - ii. **Good and bad things come with all traits**
- c. **When a trait is moderately strong it is predictive of communication tendencies two thirds of the time**

- i. If you do something 60-70% of the time it is considered a trait
- d. Most humans are average in terms of their traits
 - i. If you are average in terms of a trait it is not considered a trait of your personality
- e. Some traits have a genetic component, but nature vs. nurture is an ongoing battle within academia
- f. Most people are outliers in 3-7 traits
 - i. Either on the strong or weak side
- g. Terminology:
 - i. Strong Preference
 - ii. Moderate Preference
 - iii. Slight Preference
 - iv. Average

C. Socio-communicative Orientations (S.C.O.)

1. The Dimensions

a. Assertiveness:

- i. Standing up or speaking up to one's rights without infringing on the rights of others
- ii. The more assertive you are the more likely you are to speak up
- iii. You don't tell someone to shut up but you say "I disagree"
- iv. With Low levels of assertiveness, you don't speak up when you should
- v. Skills associated with high Assertiveness:
 - 1. Effective conversation management, and can control a conversation
 - 2. They get at the motive of a conversation easily
 - 3. They can easily dance around your questions
 - 4. Play the puppet master in a conversation
- vi. Assertiveness is common in Western Culture:
 - 1. Talk louder, faster, use eye contact and hand gestures
 - 2. If you aren't Assertive in a Western Culture you can easily get bulldozed during a conversation

b. Responsiveness:

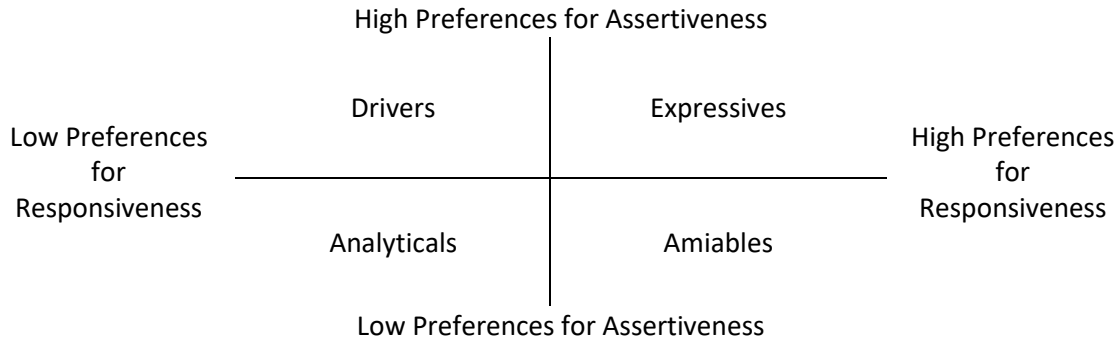
- i. Responsiveness means you are “being other oriented in your communication”**
- ii. On average the human brain can process up to 425 wpm**
 - 1. A fast rate speaker in western culture outputs ~200 wpm**
 - a. The slowest lecture by Prof. Aaron is ~300 wpm**
- iii. Responsive Person:**
 - 1. Being other oriented makes you use the left-over words of processing time (slack) during a conversation to analyze the message you received**
 - 2. High Responsiveness makes people perceive you to be sensitive and perceptive**
 - 3. Eye contact is important to being responsive**
 - 4. Responsive people use non-verbal immediacy**
 - a. Changing your posture based on the message**
 - b. Facial response (smile, shock, etc.)**
- iv. Even fake listening makes you a better listener**

c. Versatility/Flexibility:

- i. There is inconsistent/low-data research on this topic compared to the others**
 - 1. Largely theoretical**
- ii. DEF: One’s ability to adapt to their communication behavior based on the context, situation, and other person in any communicative episode**
 - 1. Essentially shaping yourself to fit the conversation**
 - 2. Get done what you need to get done**
- iii. Think about this:**
 - 1. The average member of society reads at a 5th grade level**
 - 2. So when you are addressing the public you need to change your communication style to be able to reach that audience**

II. 4 Core Orientations:

- Think about these as someone's personality
 - i. The tendencies or patterns in someone's communication
 - ii. It helps to connect these to people you already know
 - A. Ask yourself "Who in my life has these traits?"



A. Amiable:

DESCRIPTIONS:

- Amiables have high levels of responsiveness and low levels of assertiveness.
- The likeable person
- They do not speak up for themselves much but are good listeners.
 - Range from "supportive to awkward"
 - passive/avoidant, supportive, respective, aggregable (calm/collected), and awkward

IN CONFLICT:

- Amiables are passive/avoidant, respective, aggregable (calm/collected), and awkward
 - These descriptions are a range, so they will not act like this in every conflict, but this is what can be expected from them
- They will most likely avoid you in conflict. At least more than most.
- They lack conviction, they will show that they are in conflict but won't state it verbally.
 - They will avoid acknowledging that they are in a dispute

MANAGING COMMUNICATION WITH AN AMIALE IN CONFLICT:

- You should provide reassurance
 - Show them support

- Ex: “I disagree with you; this doesn’t harm our relationship”
- Be supportive in the things you don’t agree on
 - Even if you disagree

THEORETICAL BASIC NEED:

- The most valuable thing to them is their relationships
 - During a conflict they display avoidance and other traits out of fear of damaging the relationship

COMMON PROFESSIONS:

- Psychology
- Counseling
- Good in HR
 - specifically hiring
- Teachers
 - The younger the student (like elementary) the more likely the person is Amiable
- Amiables like to make low-risk decisions
 - This makes them indecisive

To NEGOTIATE with Amiables:

- Take your time and be patient with them
 - They will not challenge you
- This can be an easy win for you
 - They are the cupcake in conversation
 - But roadkill in a negotiation
- You will burn the relationship if you run them over (roadkill)
 - When others see you burn the likeable person
 - Others will see you being a dick
 - Not only will you burn your bridge with this person but with others (You lose all credibility)
- You should get to know them and let them get to know you
 - Find common ground
 - Build the relationship
- Good evidence for an Amiable:
 - Personal guarantee; “I promise...”
 - Testimonial (Endorsement); “Isaac is a cool ass dude”
 - Your opinion
- When they listen to you, they are listening for the story
- When something is guaranteed then it carries more weight for an Amiable
- You should cut out the logic, to them it isn’t as strong as a friends guarantee

B. Analytical:

DESCRIPTIONS:

- They have low responsiveness and low assertiveness
- Prefer to work with stuff, not people
- Range from “exacting to stuffy”
 - Indecisive, picky, serious, moralistic, stuffy (Don’t want to talk to people, can come across as snobby)
 - They are exacting (Precise), persistent, orderly, and industrious (They like to use their precision in an industrial setting)
- Not perfectionists
- They will not speak their mind
- Give off vibe that they think are better than you
 - They usually do not reciprocate this feeling
 - They just don’t like to talk to others
- They would rather have less interaction with people

IN CONFLICT:

- Negative in form of communication
 - Trying to shut down the conflict
- They are not “coming at you”
- Some Analyticals are very sarcastic during conflict
- Will pick you apart with precision in a conflict
- Some will come across as whining a lot
- Analyticals prefer indirect forms of communication for conflict
 - Texting or Emails (Avoiding in-person communication)

MANAGING COMMUNICATION WITH AN ANALYTICAL IN CONFLICT:

- Listen to them in a factual manner
 - Behave like you are listening to them
 - **IMPORTANT:** Actually listen to them
 - You want to use non-verbals to indicate that you are actively listening
 - Lots of eye contact
 - Turn yourself towards them
 - Relaxed body posture
 - Basically, act like a good listener
- Listening to negativity does not mean agreeing with it
- By listening intently, you are given a free pass to interrupt them

- When they begin to exaggerate you should interject and tell them something along the lines of: “You know that isn’t true.”
 - This will snap them back to reality
 - They will become more productive in the resolution of the conflict
- They do not like being corrected, so by doing this you snap them back to reality
 - As a result, they become more aware of what they say and of you
- Analyticals are not the type of people that try to validate or prove their opinion/view on life
 - They will not try to convince you of their beliefs
- They do not hold to an opinion dogmatically
 - Whatever is more accurate to them is what exists in reality

THEORETICAL BASIC NEED:

- They want to be correct
 - To have the factually correct or precise decision

PROFESSIONS:

- Hard sciences
 - Physics
 - Mathematics
 - Engineering
- Lab workers
- Some jobs in construction
 - Such as architecture
- Accountants
- The law
 - Contract lawyers
 - Lawyers that deal with papers not people

To NEGOTIATE with Analyticals:

- Your behavior
 - Behave like a decent and helpful human
 - Don’t bring them into the discussions
 - Analyticals have a level of anxiety associated with talking with other humans
 - Don’t overstate or oversell anything to them
- The Long Game:
 - They will pick who they talk to base don their actions

- Being a good or bad person at a certain point
 - This will be the decider of whether they want to communicate with you
- When communicating with an Analytical stick to the facts
 - Stick to the specifics (data, numbers, etc.)
 - Good evidence:
 - The facts, logic, and analytics
 - They do not care about narratives (The story)
- They want to hear what can go wrong
 - Where are the flaws in your idea
 - What are the problems
 - Keep in mind: They are not risk takers

C. Driver:

DESCRIPTIONS:

- High assertiveness and low responsiveness
- Range from “practical to harsh”
 - Practical, Independent, decisive, efficient, strong willed, tough, dominating, pushy, harsh
- They will talk to you, not to you
 - Drivers are not concerned about feelings

IN CONFLICT:

- Drivers are aggressive in conflict
 - Aggressive does not mean rage
 - Aggressive in this context refers to a neutral emotion
 - Think about it as them always being in overdrive
- Will you come to them or will they approach you
 - They are very likely to be the “instigator”
 - They want to come at you
- Forms of aggression:
 - Constructive aggression
 - Will attack the position of an issue
 - They will stimulate thoughts and critical thinking
 - Destructive aggression
 - “You are a dumbfuck”
 - “Back the fuck up”
 - They see themselves as the hammer and you as the nail
 - They will attack your character

- Attack the targets Self-Concept

MANAGING COMMUNICATION WITH THEM IN CONFLICT:

- Listen to them and assert a solution
- At first treat them like an Analytical
 - Be an active listener
 - Active non-verbals
- They read aggressive body posture as hostility
- You must assertive
 - They will roll you over if you aren't assertive
- Drivers approach life from a problem solution mindset
 - Everything is a problem and it needs to be fixed
 - Speak to them similarly
 - "This is the problem and here are the solutions"
 - Let the driver pick your proposed solution
- The one who gives the options has the power in this conflict
 - You should be able to live with all solutions
 - Give the illusion of control
 - They should believe they found the solution and made the decision

THEORETICAL BASIC NEED:

- Control
 - They crave control

PROFESSIONS:

- Business owners
- Upper management
 - Although very few drivers become CEO's
- Politics
 - They don't need to listen to anyone
- Any decision-making position

To NEGOTIATE with Drivers:

- Plan your conversation to be business like:
 - Efficient and to the point
 - Don't waste their time
- Phrase things in terms of being action oriented and result oriented
 - They need to hear what you want them to do
 - TELL THEM
 - Be direct
 - This form of communication is not harsh to a driver

- **Goo evidence for a Driver:**
 - **Facts**
 - **Logic**
 - **Stats**
- **Not generally risk takers but not risk averse**
- **You are wasting your breath with personal guarantees and story telling**
- **They usually do not care about opinions**
- **They tend to assert a fair number of their own opinions during communication**
- **Do not challenge their opinion**
 - **They will put energy into that negotiation**
 - **This can and will sidetrack your main negotiation**

D. Expressive:

DESCRIPTIONS:

- **High responsiveness and high assertiveness**
- **Like to both talk with others and at others**
- **Range from stimulating to egotistic**
 - **Stimulating, enthusiastic, ambitious, friendly, Dramatic, excitable, reacting**
- **Will bring emotion to any conversation**
- **Very emotionally reactive in conversation**
- **Likely to be impulsive in their reaction and conversation**
- **Expressives are considered undisciplined:**
 - **Jump from passive & active**
- **Manipulative during communication**

IN CONFLICT:

- **Highly unpredictable & emotional**
 - **You know you are going to get AN emotion**
 - **No guarantee on what emotion it will be**

MANAGING COMMUNICATION WITH THEM IN CONFLICT:

- **Composure time:**
 - **Give them time to collect their composure**
 - **They will never become completely composed during conflict**
 - **Ask them specific questions to put them into a thinking mindset**
 - **Ask as few questions as possible**
- **About 20% of people in a room are Expressives**

- Someone can step on the gas and quickly cause an Expressive to explode
 - This is a vulnerability

THEORETICAL BASIC NEED:

- They want recognition
 - They want to be acknowledged for their skill and ideas

PROFESSIONS:

- Entertainment
 - Acting
 - Music
 - Writing
- The arts
 - Sculptures
 - Painting
- Advertising
 - Make great salespeople

To NEGOTIATE with Expressives:

- Anticipate the conversation
- What evidence works:
 - Prep everything
 - People and facts
 - Prepare for them to attack you from every angle
 - Want to hear about both the facts and the narratives
 - Will ask if it is present oriented or future oriented
 - This won't always happen, but you must be prepared
- Guard them against themselves (They are undisciplined)
 - Short fast-moving messages
- Expressives are slippery during a negotiation
 - Work to pin them down in a friendly way
- Lace many summaries into the negotiation
- Don't give them lead time to think out of your propositions